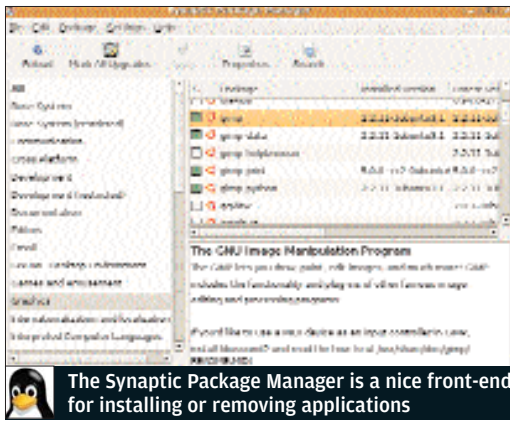




SuSE, is responsible for much of the development in the new SuSE Linux. To take on Microsoft's Vista in terms of eye candy, SuSE Linux comes with XGL X server—an OpenGL accelerated X server. Getting it started is slightly tricky, but once it's set, the effects are mind boggling! Transparent windows, 3D desktop, water effects and many other effects can

be applied. XGL is open source and can be made to run on other Linux distributions as well. Beagle, an indexing tool that debuted in SuSE Professional 9.3, works near perfectly in SuSE 10. It found all files we searched for, such as mail, documents, images, etc. AppArmor is something interesting that SuSE 10 is bestowed with. In layman's terms it's a firewall for applications—from a conceptual point of view it looks like an interesting concept. YAST (Yet Another Setup Tool) still remains the best configuration tool across the various Linux distros. One-click access to various hardware and software configuration makes life easier.

Fedora Core 5 is in no way behind the chameleon—it too comes in a five CD pack or a single DVD for download. The usual suite of applications makes its way to Fedora too. OpenOffice.org 2.0 for spreadsheets and word processing, Firefox for Internet browsing, GIMP 2.2 for image manipulation and loads of other stuff you will never use. Since Novell took over SuSE it has contributed immensely to the Open source movement by sponsoring projects that are utilised by other distribution as well. Beagle indexing tool, F-Spot photo manager, etc., are some of the fine examples. Beagle was installed by default on our test rigs, but wasn't running, and we had a little trouble hunting down documentation to get it up and running. Tomboy—again a Novell-SuSE innovation, is a nifty note-taking utility, residing besides the Applications (Start) menu. TomBoy is lightweight, making it

an ideal application for taking down phone numbers and small notes on the fly.

Mandriva 2006 is no stranger in the 'give it all' bandwagon and its PowerPlus pack with 4000-odd applications will definitely satisfy anyone's craze. The package includes the standard applications such as Firefox 1.06 (with all plug-ins included) for Internet browsing, GIMP 2.3 for image manipulation, OpenOffice.org 2.0 as the default office suite, Amarok for music, etc.

Some unique Mandriva innovations include 'Kat'—a desktop search tool. For now, Kat supports limited text formats such as PDF, MS documents, OpenOffice.org documents, HTML, etc. However, it supports wide variety of graphics formats. We would say organising your files properly is much better way of staying organised then using some indexing application. Mandriva 2006 also includes an interactive firewall. The firewall operates in two modes namely, Automatic and Interactive. As the name suggests, automatic mode protects the PC from any incoming threats by automatically adding source address to the blacklist. In the interactive mode the application prompts for user intervention by means of a small pop up.

Similar to SuSE's 'YAST' configuration tool, Mandriva has the famous control centre. It has applets for controlling various hardware and software components of the system. While it is similar in look and feel to the Windows 'Control Panel' it can't match the granularity offered by the latter from the GUI. Further, to make life easy for a beginner, Mandriva has plethora of wizards that help in setting mundane applications such as Evolution.

Xandros, on the other hand, is quite reserved in offering applications and that's understandable given the fact that it's targeted at beginners who need not require everything that is cultivated on the open source farm. The Xandros network is a common pool from where one can download and install new application that too at the click of a single button. As far as default applications are concerned they were up to date, OpenOffice.org, Firefox, KDE office suite, etc., are present. Xandros also offers Codeweaver's Crossover Office 4.1 tool. With this, it is possible to install MS Office XP, Adobe Photoshop 7, IE 6, Windows Media Player, and many more applications. Xandros file

Some Observations

A couple of years back, getting Linux running on a typical desktop machine was a pain—mostly due to hardware incompatibilities; laptops were simply out of question. However, today most Linux distributions are better suited to run on a laptop than on desktop machines. In fact almost all distro's that we tested here installed smoothly on the Dell laptop. Most surprisingly this laptop had a 15.4 inch wide-screen that is capable of reaching a resolution of 1920x 1200 and even SuSE, which had problems detecting the Samsung 17-inch monitor, detected such a esoteric resolution perfectly. What more, power management features also worked with some distro's out of the box. With SuSE we were able to suspend the laptop to hibernation. The point is, though gradually, Linux is finally getting there! We would love to see hardware manufacturers

working with these Linux vendors and providing the necessary Linux drivers, which still seems to be the Achilles heel.

On the software front, open source software is rivalling the best in the proprietary world. They have the ability to get your work done, and done quickly. A good example would be OpenOffice.org, this office suite is sufficient for day to day working. Though it does not have the ease of use that the new Office 2007 offers, it gets the work done at absolutely no price.

KDE desktop used to be the preferred desktop environment. However, GNOME seems to have caught the fancy of most Linux distributions now. Even SuSE 10 and Fedora Core 5, once ardent KDE-biased distributions, have suddenly taken a somersault and started using GNOME. We have no complaints though, the new GNOME 2.14 is slick and fast and exactly what we want.